

Susceptibility as Evidence: How Orwell Reviewed *Mein Kampf*

When confronting Adolf Hitler's *Mein Kampf*, George Orwell and the book's publishers took entirely opposite approaches. Originally, the publishers Hurst and Blackett had released an unexpurgated edition that came with a translator's preface and notes that toned down the book's ferocity.¹ Because Hitler had dismantled the German labor movement, the property-owning classes were willing to forgive him for nearly anything. Once his true nature became undeniable, however, the publishers then reissued the same edition but in a new jacket and announced that all profits from it would be pledged to the Red Cross.² Orwell took the inverse approach in which he faced something uncomfortable about Hitler's appeal, rather than merely repackaging it.

Unlike the publishers, who attempted to distance themselves from the text and Hitler himself, Orwell directly addresses his own vulnerability to Hitler's appeal. He admits that he has "never been able to dislike Hitler," then says "I have reflected that I would certainly kill him if I could get within reach of him, but that I could feel no personal animosity."³ Orwell notes that "till then, like nearly everyone, I had been deceived into thinking that he did not matter." He further acknowledges the undeniable power of Hitler's attractive and charismatic personality, by noting that it is a force "which one can feel even in the clumsy writing of *Mein Kampf*, and which is no doubt overwhelming when one hears his speeches."⁴ Orwell does not leave the reader with a vague description of how Hitler was appealing; instead, he directs the reader where to look: "...and I recommend especially the photograph at the beginning of Hurst and Blackett's edition, which shows Hitler in his early Brownshirt days." In this photograph, Orwell sees something specific, notably "...a pathetic, dog-like face, the face of a man suffering under intolerable wrongs. In a rather more manly way, it reproduces the expression of innumerable pictures of Christ crucified, and there is little doubt that that is how Hitler sees himself."⁵ Orwell first begins with an account of his own susceptibility and eventually reaches a conclusion of how Hitler understood himself.

Hurst and Blackett's change was to the outside of the book. Orwell states simply that nothing inside it had changed. The text remained the same. Orwell changed neither the wrapping nor the text and instead turned his own reaction into the instrument of examination. Two methods were used; one leaves the reader knowing nothing he did not know before, since a jacket reveals something about the publisher rather than about Hitler or the text inside. The other method produced a stark difference; the conclusion that Hitler may very well imagine himself as Christ, which only exists because Orwell admitted the appeal worked on him. Susceptibility evolved into evidence. By contrast, Klimov and Burgess put distance between an audience and an atrocity by antithetical means. Yet Orwell's solution was to remove the distance entirely.

¹ George Orwell, review of *Mein Kampf*, by Adolf Hitler, *New English Weekly*, March 21, 1940, in *George Orwell* (London: Book Club Associates, 1981), 523.

² Orwell, review of *Mein Kampf*, 523.

³ Orwell, review of *Mein Kampf*, 523-24.

⁴ Orwell, review of *Mein Kampf*, 523-24.

⁵ Orwell, review of *Mein Kampf*, 524.